

Spreading Out Across Expanding Idea Space

Ina Ganguli

UMass-Amherst

Jeffrey Lin

FRB Philadelphia

Vitaly Meursault

FRB Philadelphia

Nicholas Reynolds

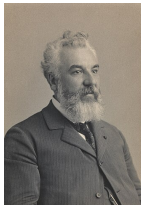
University of Essex

October 2026

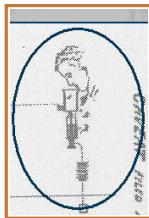
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February 14, 1876: A Collision in Idea Space



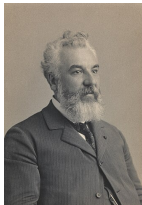
Alexander Graham Bell



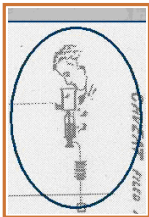
Elisha Gray

A **patent interference** — two inventors, same invention

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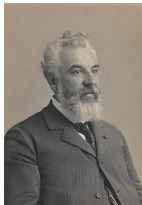


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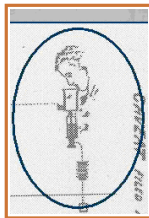


If every invention a
"location" in idea space

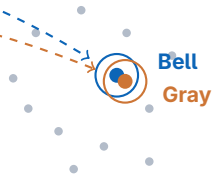
February 14, 1876: A Collision in Idea Space



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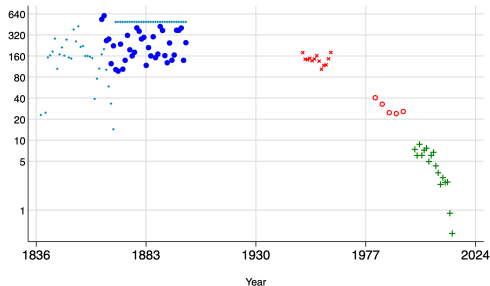
A **patent interference** — two inventors, **same invention** $\leftarrow - - \rightarrow$

They chose the **same location** in idea space

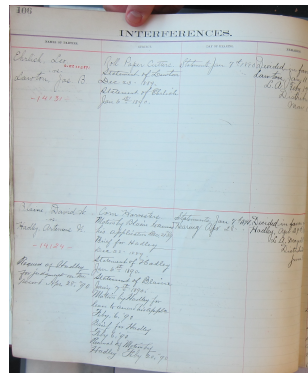
Such Collisions Were Once Routine

≈ 1 in 20 patents (1870s) $\rightarrow <1$ in 10,000 (2014)

Interference rate per 10,000



• Finding Guide • Registers • Di Simone et al. • Calvert-Sofocleous • eFOIA decisions

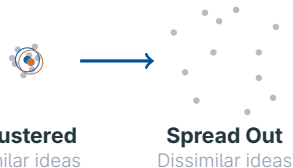
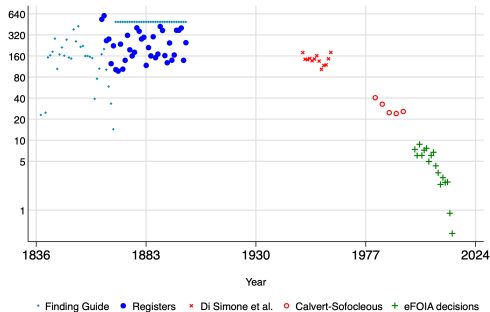


► Data ► Robustness

Such Collisions Were Once Routine

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Interference rate per 10,000



Inventors spread out
across expanding idea space

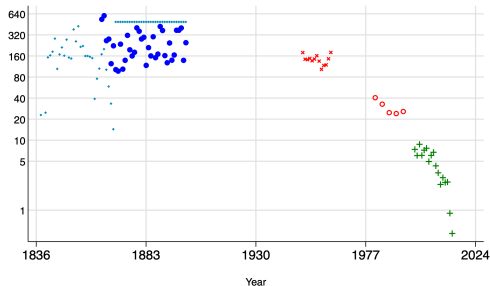
► Data

► Robustness

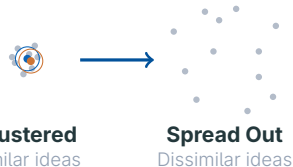
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Inventors spread out
across expanding idea space

Their positions
matter for growth

► Data

► Robustness

Three Questions, Three Routes

Questions

1. Are inventions spreading out?
2. Why are they spreading out?
3. What are the consequences?

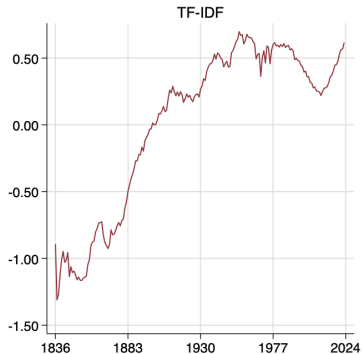
How we answer

1. Build and validate a **map of inventions**
2. Model how **entry and competition** determine spacing
3. Trace how spacing shapes **invention scale, spillovers, and growth**

Are Inventions Spreading Out?

Let's Check with Text

Standardized avg pairwise cosine similarity by year



Data: Claims text of 11M+ US patents

Standard Tool: **TF-IDF** word frequencies

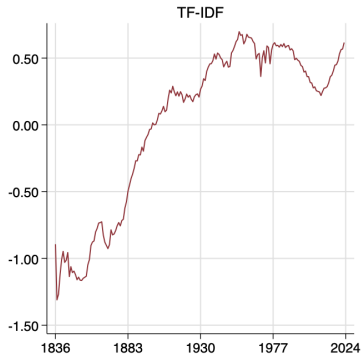
► Corpus

► Computation

► Standardization

Let's Check with Text

Standardized avg pairwise cosine similarity by year



Data: Claims text of 11M+ US patents

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Similarity is rising?

× Inventions appear to be *crowding*.

► Corpus

► Computation

► Standardization

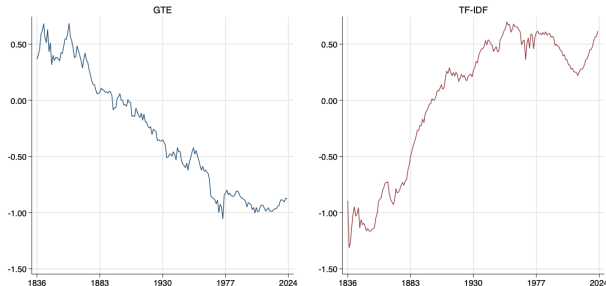
Same Text, Opposite Maps

Seven representations:

TF-IDF · GTE · PaECTER · S-BERT
Doc2Vec · USE · OpenAI

Divergent conclusions:

- TF-IDF: similarity *rising*
- Others: similarity *falling*



Which “map” should we trust?

Validation Across Judges, Scales, and Eras

Judge / benchmark	Scale	Era
Examiners / Interferences	Same invention	2001–2014
RAs / Pair comparisons	Relative similarity	1850–1975
Examiners / Classifications	Technology categories	1850–2023

► Interferences

► Human judgments

► Classifications

Validation Selects GTE Embeddings

		Same - invention collisions	Human rankings	Shared CPC categories	
		F10	Agreement	Section ROC	Class ROC
✓	GTE	0.90	0.62	0.596	0.656
	PaECTER	0.90	0.51	0.590	0.672
	S-BERT	0.82	0.54	0.600	0.671
×	TF-IDF	0.77	0.35	0.514	0.525

Higher is better in every column

✓ **Select GTE**

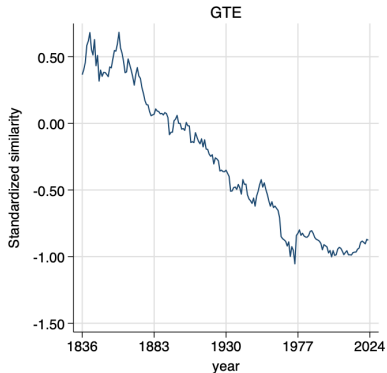
Consistent across benchmarks

× **TF-IDF ranks last**

On every benchmark

► bicycle ≠ velocipede

Validated Maps Agree: Inventions Are Spreading Out



About $1-1.5\sigma$ less similar

1838–2023, GTE

Three validated maps agree

GTE, PaECTER, S-BERT

Also locally and within fields

► Independent inventions

► Local / within fields

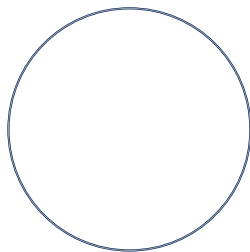
► Frontier

Why Are Inventions Spreading Out?

Spacing Gives Inventors Market Power

Idea space: circumference H

Similar problems, similar solutions



Spacing Gives Inventors Market Power

Idea space: circumference H

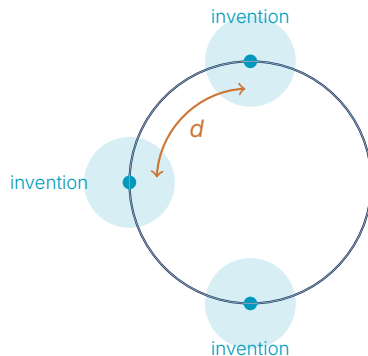
Similar problems, similar solutions

Inventors sell non-exclusive licenses

Pay entry cost f ; choose a location

Choose quality q_i and price p_i

$$\pi_i = R_i - c(q_i) - f$$



Spacing Gives Inventors Market Power

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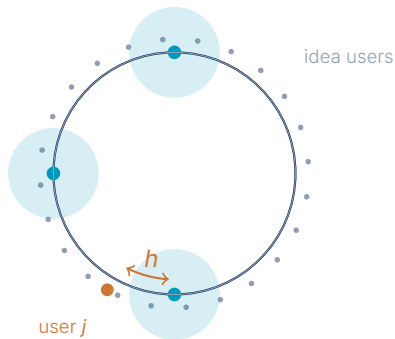
Choose quality q_i and price p_i

$$\pi_i = R_i - c(q_i) - f$$

Users buy one idea to improve TFP

Uniformly distributed on the circle

Net surplus: $Q_i - \tau h - p_i$ ► TFP



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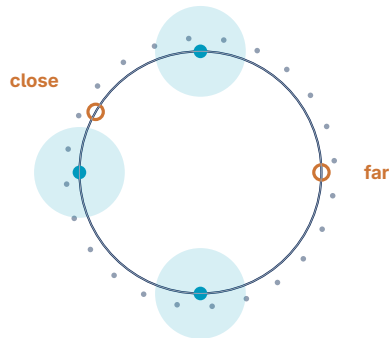
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Distance reduces close substitutes.



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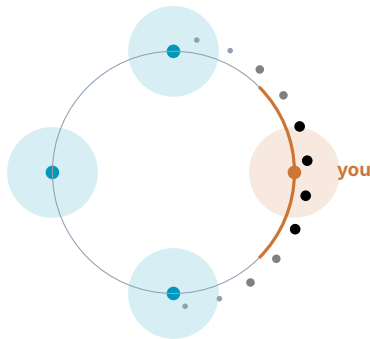
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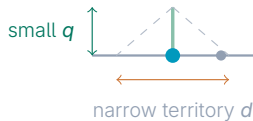
Net surplus: $Q_i - \tau h - p_i$ ► TFP

**Distance reduces close substitutes.
Isolation widens your market.**



A Larger Territory Requires a Larger Invention

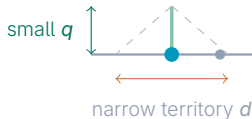
Close to neighboring inventor



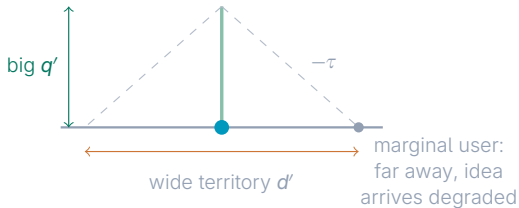
Your marginal user is $d/2$ away.

A Larger Territory Requires a Larger Invention

Close to neighboring inventor



Far from neighboring inventor



Your marginal user is $d/2$ away.

Wider spacing raises adaptation costs.

A larger quality gain makes the invention worth using farther away.

A wider territory calls for a larger invention.

Spacing Pins Prices and Quality

► Detailed

► Existence

► $\tau\gamma > 1/2$

► Comparative statics

► Equations

1. Price:

$$p^* = \tau d$$



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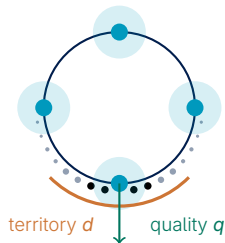
1. Price:

$$p^* = \tau d$$

2. Quality investment:

$$q^* = d/\gamma$$

$$c(q) = \frac{1}{2}\tau q^2$$



Spacing Pins Prices and Quality

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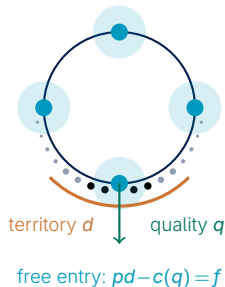
2. Quality investment:

$$q^* = d/\gamma$$

$$c(q) = \frac{1}{2}\gamma q^2$$

3. Free entry:

$$d^* = \sqrt{\frac{f}{\tau - 1/(2\gamma)}}$$



Frontier Expansion Changes Equilibrium Spacing

Inventions open new directions Weitzman (1998)

$$\dot{H} = \delta n \left(Q - \frac{\tau d}{4} \right)$$



► Free entry

► Frontier law

► Scenarios

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Entry becomes more costly Jones (2009)

$$f(H) = \phi H^\alpha \quad \alpha = 1 \text{ in the baseline}$$



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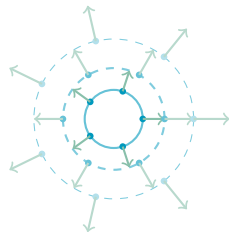
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Free entry requires wider spacing

$$d^* \uparrow \quad \text{and} \quad q^* = d^* / \gamma \uparrow$$



The Ripple: $H \uparrow \longrightarrow f \uparrow \longrightarrow d, q \uparrow \longrightarrow H \uparrow$

Inventors spread out and build bigger.

► Free entry

► Frontier law

► Scenarios

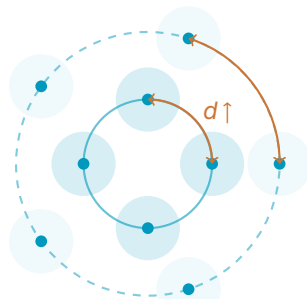
The Ripple's Fade: Attenuating Knowledge Spillovers

Quality gains include direct diffusion from local spillovers:

$$Q_i = \underbrace{q_i}_{\text{purchased idea}} + \underbrace{\beta\left(1 - \frac{d}{\lambda}\right)}_{\substack{\text{spillovers} \\ \text{(declines with } d\text{)}}} q$$

An endogenous brake on growth

Spreading weakens the contribution of neighboring inventions.



halos fade: $\beta(1 - d/\lambda) \rightarrow 0$

cf. Fort et al. 2026

Local TFP Gains, Economy - Wide R&D Costs

Nonrival ideas are **only locally useful** here (cf. Romer 1990).

R&D
productivity

$$\Pi \equiv \frac{g_{TFP}}{\text{Agg R\&D}}$$

cf. Bloom et al. 2020

Local TFP Gains, Economy - Wide R&D Costs

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R&D productivity

$$\Pi \equiv \frac{g_{TFP}}{\text{Agg R\&D}}$$

TFP: average local gains

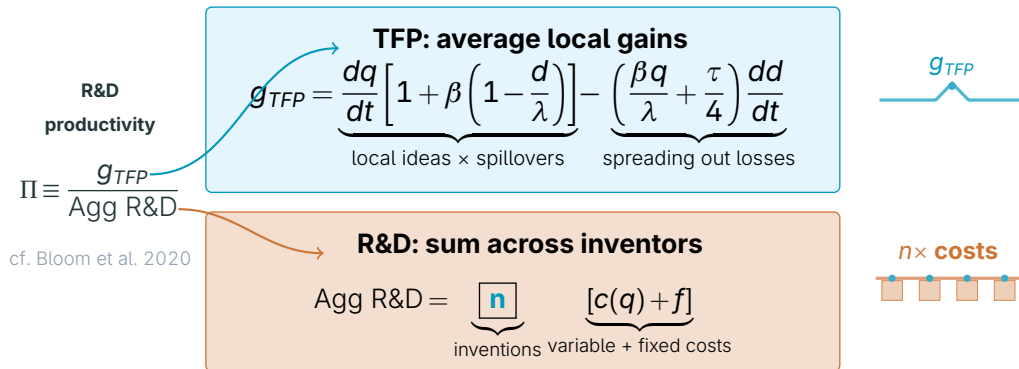
$$g_{TFP} = \underbrace{\frac{dq}{dt} \left[1 + \beta \left(1 - \frac{d}{\lambda} \right) \right]}_{\text{local ideas} \times \text{spillovers}} - \underbrace{\left(\frac{\beta q}{\lambda} + \frac{\tau}{4} \right) \frac{dd}{dt}}_{\text{spreading out losses}}$$

g_{TFP}

cf. Bloom et al. 2020

Local TFP Gains, Economy - Wide R&D Costs

Nonrival ideas are **only locally useful** here (cf. Romer 1990).



► Decomposition

Equilibrium Spacing Enters the Growth Rate

Growth depends on the distance between inventions

$$g_H(t) = \underbrace{\delta \left(\frac{1}{\gamma} - \frac{\tau}{4} \right)}_{\text{R\&D and adaptation costs}} + \underbrace{\frac{\delta \beta}{\gamma} \left(1 - \frac{d(t)}{\lambda} \right)}_{\text{spillovers weaken as spacing rises}}$$

Baseline frontier law; active spillovers ($d < \lambda$)

► Growth equations

► General model

► Equations

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Wider spacing weakens spillovers and slows frontier growth.

Baseline frontier law; active spillovers ($d < \lambda$)

► Growth equations

► General model

► Equations

Growth depends on more than a scalar knowledge stock.

Equilibrium Positioning Shapes Growth

Growth depends on more than a scalar knowledge stock.

Positioning makes key growth objects equilibrium outcomes.

	Canonical treatment	Here: equilibrium spacing
Romer (1990)	Broad knowledge reuse	Local spillovers: $\beta(1 - d^*/\lambda)$
Jones (1995)	Research scale; imposed diminishing returns	Entry $n^* = H/d^*$; declining research productivity
Aghion–Howitt (1992)	Given innovation step size	Innovation scale: $q^* = d^*/\gamma$

What Are the Consequences?

One Geometry Unifies Many Facts

Spreading out

Patent similarity falls

This paper; Chiopris 2024

Spillovers weaken

Lucking+ 19; Fort+ 26;

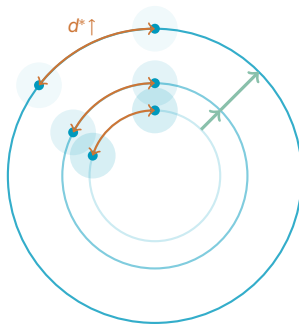
Berkes–Gaetani 26

Research productivity falls

Jones 95; Kortum 97; Bloom+ 20

Varieties increase

Patent counts; Hirschey+ 12



► Comparative statics

► Kelly replication

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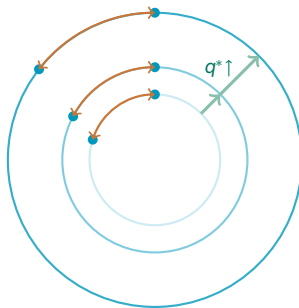
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Building bigger

R&D rises

Hirschey+ 12

Breakthrough rates rise

Kelly+ 2021

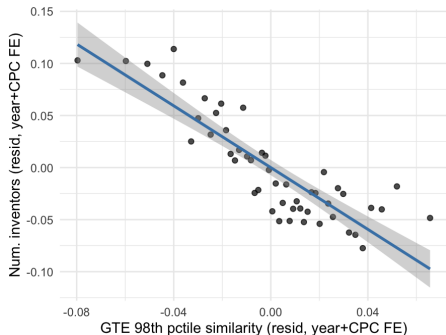
Patent values rise

Hall+ 05; Bessen+ 18; Kogan+ 17

► Comparative statics

► Kelly replication

The Model's Fingerprint: Spacing Couples with Quality



Co-inventors vs. similarity
residualized on year × CPC class

Wider spacing predicts larger inventions:

$$q^* = d/\gamma$$

More isolated inventions:

- Use **larger teams**
- More often **firm - assigned**
- More often **cited**
- Have **higher market value**

(KPSS: ≈\$22–33M per σ of isolation)

Within class-year; consistent with the mechanism.

► All four proxies

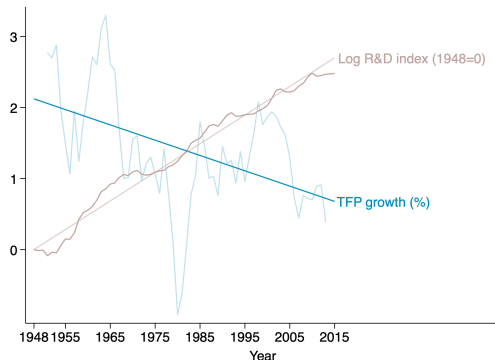
► Regression table

Research Productivity Falls Through Two Margins

$$g_{\Pi} = \underbrace{g_{g_{TFP}}}_{-1.6\%/yr} - \underbrace{g_{R\&D}}_{+4.0\%/yr} = \boxed{-5.6\%/yr}$$

How much of the **TFP-growth slowdown** comes from spreading?

How much of **R&D growth** comes from **novel** spatial forces?

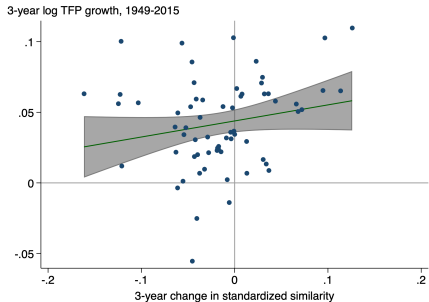


Bloom, Jones, Van Reenen and Webb, 2020

Strategy: Quantify the spatial contribution to each margin, then add them.

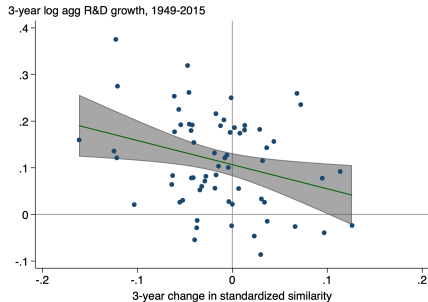
The Data Supply Two Moments

TFP margin



More spreading, slower TFP growth

R&D margin



More spreading, faster R&D growth

The model interprets these comovements

The TFP Effect of Spreading Depends on Existing Spacing

Spacing raises quality but weakens spillovers.

The marginal TFP gain from further spreading therefore falls with spacing.

$$g_{TFP} = \left[\frac{1 + \beta}{\gamma} - \frac{\tau}{4} - \frac{2\beta}{\gamma\lambda} d \right] \Delta d$$

► Accounting bridge

► TFP estimates

► Bloom comparison

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$$\Delta \log TFP_t = b_0 + b_1 \Delta D_t + b_2 D_{t-1} \Delta D_t + b_3 t + \epsilon_t$$

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Contribution to the decline in the TFP growth rate, 1948–2015

Spatial contribution to $g_{g_{TFP}}$: **−0.11 pp/year**

1981–2001 check: −0.16 pp/yr (ours) vs. −0.15 (Bloom+2013 quasi-experiment)

► Accounting bridge

► TFP estimates

► Bloom comparison

Spreading Raises R&D When Quality Costs Dominate

Spreading raises quality costs but slows entry

$$g_{R\&D} = \underbrace{[1 + \alpha(1 - \theta)]g_H}_{\text{frontier expansion}} + \underbrace{[\theta(1 + \eta) - 1]g_d}_{\text{quality costs less entry}}$$

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The trend absorbs frontier growth during the transition

$$g_{R\&D,t} = a_0 + a_1 t + a_2 \Delta D_t + \epsilon_t$$

► Regression table

► Accounting

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Slope: variable - cost share

$$\hat{\theta} = \frac{\hat{a}_2 + 1}{1 + \eta} = 0.719$$

Intercept: frontier growth

$$\hat{g}_H^{1991} = \frac{\hat{a}_0/5}{1 + \alpha(1 - \hat{\theta})} = 2.70\%/yr$$

► Regression table

► Accounting

Baseline input	Value	Source / check
Variable-cost share θ	0.69	NSF survey; regression: 0.719
Frontier growth g_H	2.67%/yr	Model identity; regression: 2.70%/yr
Burden of knowledge α	1	$f(H) = \phi H$
Fishing out η	1	$c(q) = \frac{1}{2}\gamma q^2$

[► R&D estimates](#)[► Calibration details](#)[► All checks](#)

Baseline Model Accounting: A 42% Spatial Share

Component	pp/yr	Model contribution
TFP-growth decline	-1.60	
Spatial contribution	-0.11	
Other factors	-1.49	
Aggregate R&D growth	+4.00	
Entry across expanding idea space	+1.33	$(1 - \alpha/2)g_H$
Quality investment for wider territories	+0.92	$(\theta \alpha/2)g_H$
Fishing out	+0.92	$(\theta \eta \alpha/2)g_H$
Burden of knowledge	+0.83	$(1 - \theta)\alpha g_H$

$$\text{Spatial share: } \frac{0.11 + 1.33 + 0.92}{5.6} = 42\%$$

Parameter sensitivity

33–58%

Mainly α

► Detailed accounting

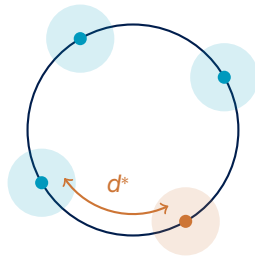
► Sensitivity

The Spatial Equilibrium of Invention Matters for Growth

Inventors choose research directions in response to competitors.

Their spacing shapes market power, quality investment, and access to neighboring knowledge.

The resulting spatial equilibrium shapes growth.



Three Takeaways

1

Inventions spread out

Validated patent text and interference records.

2

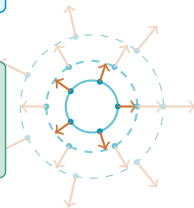
Inventors' equilibrium positioning shapes growth

Spacing shapes innovation scale and effective spillovers.

3

Spatial forces: 42% of the R&D productivity decline

Where inventors stand matters for growth



Backup Slides

Backup: Interference Data

◀ Return

NAME OF PATENT	DATE	DATE OF BLINDING	DATE OF DECISION
Ehrlich, Lee Lawton, Jan 13 - 14131 -	Roll Paper Cutters, (Patented Jan 7 1890) Decided in favor of Lawton, May 1890 D. O. Wiley 1890 Rehearsal March 1890		
Blaine, David H. Hadley, Oct 20, 90 - 14124 - Recess of Hadley for judgment on the Patent, Apr. 20, 90	Corn Harvesters. Patented March 28, 1890. Decided in favor of Hadley, Apr 28, 1890. D. O. Wiley 1890 Rehearsal June 1890		

Example (Jan 7, 1890)

Ehrlich v. Lawton: Roll paper cutters

Blaine v. Hadley: Corn harvesters

Purpose - digitized from National Archives:

- USPTO *Registers of Interferences*, 1864–1900
- 19,388 interference cases documented
- Average 504/year (2.7–4.9%)

Other sources:

- Case Files (1838–1900): 87–880/year
- DiSimone et al. (1950–1962): 640/year (1.4%)
- Calvert & Sofocleous (1980–1994): 237/yr (0.3%)
- Ganguli et al. (1998–2014): 76/year (0.05%)

Backup: Patent Corpus Details

[◀ Return](#)

Historical (1836–1975): ProQuest Patents Core

- OCR - digitized patent images
- Full text of claims extracted
- Quality varies with original document condition

Modern (1976–2023): USPTO PatentsView

- Machine - readable full text
- Structured data with claim parsing
- Consistent quality

Potential discontinuity at 1976:

- Some evidence of break in levels
- Trends consistent across periods
- Results robust to excluding transition years

Backup: Computing Similarity Efficiently

[◀ Return](#)

Challenge: $O(N^2)$ pairwise comparisons infeasible for millions of patents

Solution: For unit-normalized vectors, average cosine similarity reduces to:

$$\bar{S} = \frac{1}{N(N-1)} \sum_{i \neq j} \cos(v_i, v_j) = \frac{\|\sum_i v_i\|^2 - N}{N(N-1)}$$

Complexity: $O(N \cdot d)$ where d = embedding dimension

Implementation:

1. Normalize all vectors to unit length
2. Sum vectors: $S = \sum_i v_i$
3. Compute $\|S\|^2$
4. Apply formula

Cross-sectional SD: Subsample up to 10,000 patents/year

Main specification: Standardize by annual cross-sectional SD

Robustness checks:

1. Time-invariant global SD → Nearly identical results
2. Raw similarity (no standardization) → Same qualitative pattern
3. Different sample sizes per year → Robust

Why standardize?

- Different representations have different scales
- No intrinsic economic interpretation of raw similarity
- SD provides meaningful units for comparison

Backup: Interference Validation Task

[◀ Return](#)

Patent interferences (2001–2014):

- **First to invent:** USPTO proceeding for multiple applicants w/ identical claims
- Provides ground truth for “identical” similarity
- 322 true interfering pairs among 96,580 application pairs

Economic intuition: Examiner ranks pairs by similarity, investigates above threshold

- Higher threshold → fewer false positives but miss true interferences
- Lower threshold → catch more but burden staff with unnecessary investigations

Metrics:

- F10: Weights recall 10× more than precision (missing interferences is costly)
- PR AUC: Precision-Recall area under curve across all thresholds

Key result: GTE, PaECTER, OpenAI retrieve ~90% of true interferences with 2–5× fewer false positives than TF-IDF/S-BERT

Backup: Human Annotation Task

[◀ Return](#)

Historical patents (1850–1975):

- Sampled patent pairs that each model ranked at least 50 percentiles apart
- Annotators rank **relative** similarity of 2 patent pairs
- Tests temporal robustness (historical language): Oversample 1880–1920

Task: Do model rankings agree with human rankings?

- For each patent, rank others by similarity
- Compare model ranking to human ranking

Metric: Agreement coefficient from regression

$$\text{Human Rank} = \alpha + \beta \cdot \text{Model Rank} + \epsilon$$

Higher β = better agreement

Backup: Classification Validation Task

[◀ Return](#)

USPTO Classifications (1850–2023):

- CPC technology codes assigned by examiners
- Section level (8 categories) and Class level (120+ categories)
- Captures expert judgment of technological relatedness

Task: Predict whether patent pair shares classification

- Same Section (coarse): 8 top-level categories
- Same Class (fine): 3-digit classification

Metric: ROC AUC

- Area under Receiver Operating Characteristic curve
- 0.5 = random, 1.0 = perfect

Backup: Why TF-IDF Fails

[◀ Return](#)

TF-IDF overweights period-specific language:

- Treats “velocipede” (1880s) and “bicycle” (modern) as unrelated
- Period-specific terminology dominates similarity scores
- Creates spurious correlation with time

Example: 1880 velocipede patent

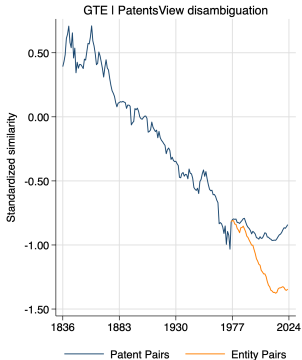
- TF-IDF: High similarity to other 1880s patents (shared vocabulary)
- GTE: High similarity to modern bicycle patents (shared concepts)

Evidence:

- TF-IDF similarity correlates with word overlap
- GTE similarity correlates with conceptual similarity
- Google Ngrams shows vocabulary shifts over time

Backup: Robustness — Multi-Patent Entities

◀ Return



Concern: Post-2000 dynamics coincide with: business method patents, non-practicing entities, increased defensive patenting.

▶ Patents v entities

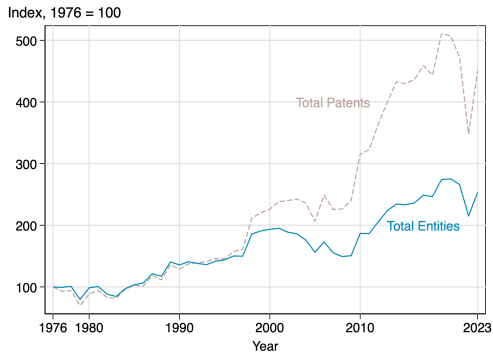
- **Multiple patents from same entity may be similar but not independent.**

Strategy: Sample 1 patent/entity-year

Result:

- Decline persists after correction
- **Independent inventions** still spreading out

Backup: Growth in Patents vs. Patenting Entities

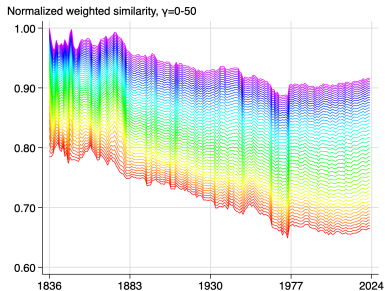
[◀ Main deck](#)[◀ Return](#)

- Number of issued utility patents and unique patenting entities per year
- Divergence after 1999: substantial growth in patents per entity
- Coincides with business method patents and non-practicing entities
- Motivates sampling 1 patent per entity per year for robustness

Backup: Spreading Occurs Nearby and Within Fields

◀ Return

Even among nearby inventions



Greater weight on near neighbors

Even within technology classes



Within three - character CPC classes

The model needs to explain local spacing

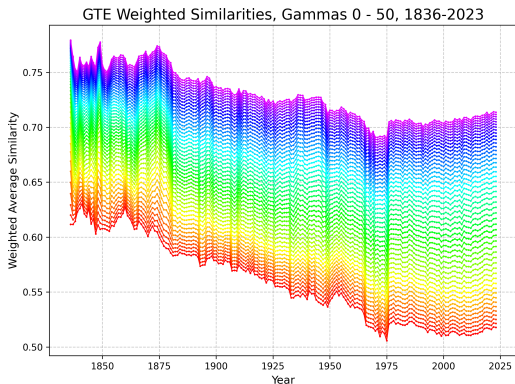
► Spatial scales

► Quantiles

► Within / between

► Class age

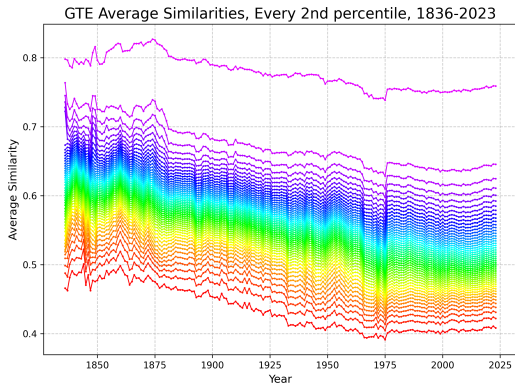
Backup: Similarity at Different Spatial Scales

[◀ Main deck](#)[◀ Robustness](#)

Weighted average: $\equiv \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n \frac{\sum_{j \neq i} (1-d_{ij}) e^{-\gamma d_{ij}}}{\sum_{j \neq i} e^{-\gamma d_{ij}}}$
where γ from 0 (global) to 50 (local)

- **Key finding:** Similar declining trends across all spatial scales
- Model predictions concern averages — important to verify pattern holds across distribution
- Post-2000 arrest slightly stronger at local scales (consistent with entity correction)

Backup: Similarity at Different Quantiles

[◀ Main deck](#)[◀ Robustness](#)

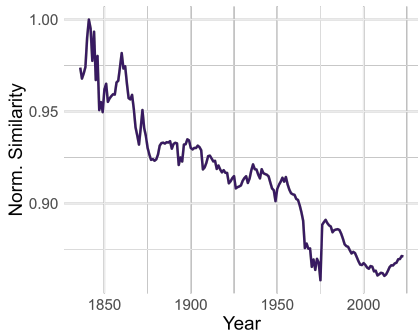
Similarity at Different Quantiles:

- 50 quantiles of pairwise similarity in each year
- Secular decline is robust across all quantiles
- Post-2000 increase in similarity is slightly faster for higher quantiles

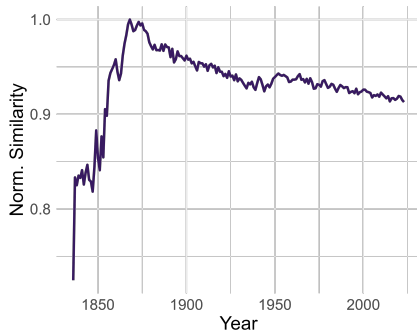
Backup: Within vs. Between Technology Classes

[◀ Main deck](#)[◀ Within classes](#)[◀ Robustness](#)

Within-class similarity



Between-class similarity



- **Addresses compositional concern:** Decline not driven by shifts across technology fields — spreading out occurs *within* established classes

Backup: Robustness — Spreading Out Within Technology Classes

◀ Main deck

◀ Robustness

Alternative explanations: Changing patent office practice over time? Shifts across major technology areas?

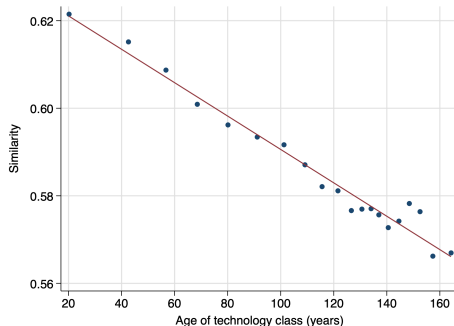
Test: Within-class similarity by class “age”

- Birth = Class first issued 50 patents
- e.g., Combinatorial Chemistry 2001
- Addresses compositional concerns

▶ Between

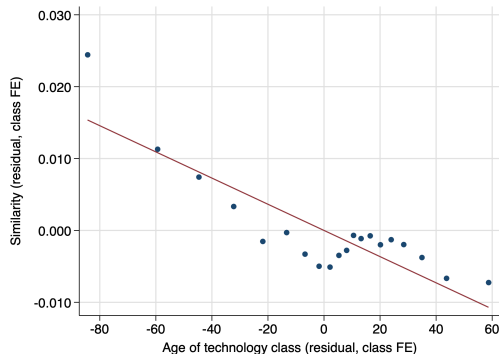
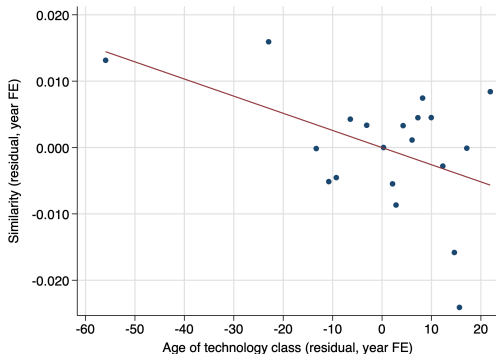
Finding: Within-class similarity declines as classes mature

▶ Class+Year FE



Spreading out is a dynamic process tied to field evolution

Backup: Similarity Within Class by Class Age

[◀ Main deck](#)[◀ Return](#)

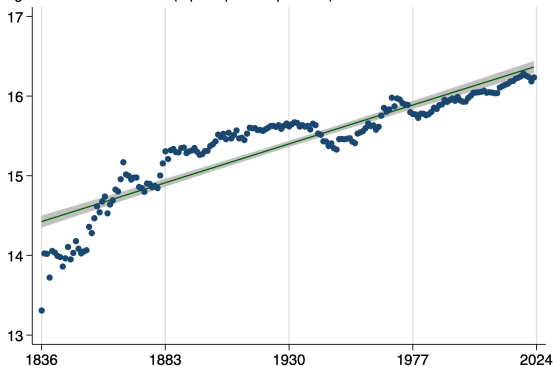
Left: Cross-cohort comparison (year FE) — robustness to patent office practice

Right: Within-cohort comparison (class FE) — robustness to composition

Corroboration: Expanding Convex Hull

◀ Robustness

Log volume of convex hull (7 principal components)



Log TFP Specification

◀ Return

Why linear in log TFP? $A_i(h) = Q_i - \tau h$

Standard in spatial competition (Salop 1979):

- Idea consumers have preferences linear in quality net of distance costs
- $A_i(h)$ interpreted as log TFP $\Rightarrow$ firms care about *proportional* productivity gains

Microfoundation: Each downstream firm has one unit of fixed input ℓ and produces:

$$y = e^A \cdot \ell$$

With output price = 1 and $\ell = 1$, profit is $\pi = e^A$. Willingness to pay for technology delivering incremental log TFP A (relative to baseline $e^0 = 1$):

$$WTP = e^A - 1 \approx A \quad (\text{first-order Taylor approximation})$$

Accuracy: For annual TFP increments ($A \approx 0.015/\text{year}$), approximation error $< 0.01\%$

Advantage: Predictions directly comparable to empirical TFP elasticities (Bloom et al. 2013) and growth accounting (Bloom et al. 2020)

Equilibrium: Pricing and Quality

Symmetric equilibrium: n inventors, equal spacing $d = H/n$, identical (p, q)

◀ Return

1. Pricing. Boundary firm at $\tilde{h}$ indifferent between inventor i and neighbor:

$$Q - p_i - \tau \tilde{h} = Q - p - \tau(d - \tilde{h}) \Rightarrow \tilde{h} = \frac{d}{2} + \frac{p - p_i}{2\tau}$$

Revenue $R_i = 2p_i \tilde{h}$; FOC $\partial R_i / \partial p_i = 0$ yields: $p^* = \tau d$

2. Quality. MR = MC for quality investment ($\partial Q_i / \partial q_i = 1$, $\partial \tilde{h} / \partial Q_i = 1/2\tau$):

$$\frac{p_i}{\tau} = \gamma q_i \Rightarrow q^* = \frac{d}{\gamma} \quad (\eta = 1)$$

3. Zero-profit condition. Substitute $R = \tau d^2$, $c(q^*) = \frac{d^2}{2\gamma}$:

$$\tau d^2 - \frac{d^2}{2\gamma} - f = 0 \Rightarrow d^* = \sqrt{\frac{f}{\tau - \frac{1}{2\gamma}}}$$

Backup: Equilibrium Existence Conditions

Spreading - out condition: ▶ Proposition

◀ Return

$$\tau\gamma > \frac{1}{2}$$

Marginal revenue of expanding territory exceeds marginal cost.

Second-order conditions:

- Pricing: $\partial^2 R / \partial p^2 < 0$ (satisfied)
- Quality: $\partial^2 \pi / \partial q^2 = -\gamma < 0$ (satisfied)
- No spatial deviation (verified in paper)

Additional conditions:

- Spillover reach: $d < \lambda$ (spillovers active)
- Full coverage: All downstream firms adopt some technology

[◀ Return](#)

Proposition (Spreading Out)

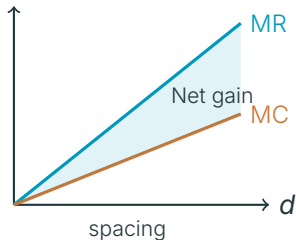
For $\tau\gamma > \frac{1}{2}$, equilibrium spacing increases with opportunity space: $\frac{dd^*}{dH} > 0$.
Inventions become **less similar** over time.

Adaptation costs must create sufficient pricing power

[▶ Intuition](#)

Backup: Spreading Out — Why Is It Profitable?

Why is spreading out profitable?



Marginal revenue of expanding territory:

- Revenue $R = \tau d^2 \Rightarrow MR = 2\tau d$

Marginal cost of expanding territory:

- Need higher quality: $q = d/\gamma$
- $MC = d/\gamma$

Spreading profitable when:

$$MR > MC \Rightarrow \boxed{\tau\gamma > \frac{1}{2}}$$

Adaptation costs must create sufficient pricing power

◀ Main deck

◀ Proposition

Backup: Comparative Statics Derivations

Spreading out: From zero-profit condition $d^2(\tau - \frac{1}{2\gamma}) = \phi H$:

◀ Equilibrium

◀ Literature Evidence

$$\frac{dd}{dH} = \frac{\phi}{2d(\tau - \frac{1}{2\gamma})} = \frac{\phi}{dR/dd - dc/dd} > 0$$

Rising quality and prices:

$$\frac{dq}{dH} = \frac{1}{\gamma} \frac{dd}{dH} > 0, \quad \frac{dp}{dH} = \tau \frac{dd}{dH} > 0$$

Rising entry:

$$\frac{dn}{dH} = \frac{1}{d} - \frac{H}{d^2} \frac{dd}{dH} > 0 \text{ under spreading-out condition}$$

Declining R&D productivity: See ▶ Force decomposition

Backup: Model Equations

◀ Equilibrium

◀ Growth rates

Fixed cost (burden of knowledge):	$f(H) = \phi H^\alpha$
R&D cost:	$c(q_i) = \frac{1}{2} \gamma q_i^{1+\eta}$
Realized quality (with spillovers):	$Q_i = q_i + \frac{1}{2} \beta \left(1 - \frac{d}{\lambda}\right) (q_{i-1} + q_{i+1})$

Equilibrium pricing and quality:	$p^* = \tau d, \quad q^* = \frac{d}{\gamma}$
Equilibrium spacing:	$d^*(H) = \sqrt{\frac{\phi H}{\tau - \frac{1}{2\gamma}}}$
Equilibrium entry:	$n^* = \frac{H}{d^*}$
Equilibrium revenue:	$R^* = p^* \cdot d^* = \tau d^2$

Growth rates (baseline $\alpha = 1, \eta = 1$):

Spacing, quality, entry:	$g_d = g_q = g_n = \frac{1}{2} g_H$
Fixed cost:	$g_f = g_H$
Aggregate R&D:	$g_{R\&D} = \frac{3}{2} g_H$

Backup: Rising Entry Costs Require Wider Territories

Revenue

$$R = pd = \tau d^2$$

Variable cost

$$c(q) = \frac{1}{2}\gamma q^2 = \frac{d^2}{2\gamma}$$

◀ Return

$\tau\gamma > 1/2$; both margins rise when $0 < \alpha < 2$

▶ Entry costs

Backup: Rising Entry Costs Require Wider Territories

[◀ Return](#)

Revenue

$$R = pd = \tau d^2$$

Variable cost

$$c(q) = \frac{1}{2}\gamma q^2 = \frac{d^2}{2\gamma}$$

Free entry: revenue covers variable and fixed costs

$$d^2 \left(\tau - \frac{1}{2\gamma} \right) = \phi H^\alpha$$

$\tau\gamma > 1/2$; both margins rise when $0 < \alpha < 2$

[▶ Entry costs](#)

Backup: Rising Entry Costs Require Wider Territories

◀ Return

Revenue

$$R = pd = \tau d^2$$

Variable cost

$$c(q) = \frac{1}{2}\gamma q^2 = \frac{d^2}{2\gamma}$$

Free entry: revenue covers variable and fixed costs

$$d^2 \left(\tau - \frac{1}{2\gamma} \right) = \phi H^\alpha$$

Wider spacing

$$d \propto H^{\alpha/2}$$

More inventions

$$n = H/d \propto H^{1-\alpha/2}$$

$\tau\gamma > 1/2$; both margins rise when $0 < \alpha < 2$

▶ Entry costs

Backup: Robustness to Entry Cost Curvature

[◀ Return](#)

With $f(H) = \phi H^\alpha$, equilibrium spacing satisfies $d \propto H^{\alpha/2}$:

Condition	Entry Growth	Prediction
$0 < \alpha < 2$	$g_n = (1 - \frac{\alpha}{2})g_H > 0$	Entry grows ✓
$\alpha = 2$	$g_n = 0$	Entry stagnates
$\alpha > 2$	$g_n < 0$	Entry declines ×

Main results robust for $\alpha < 2$:

- Spreading out: $g_d = \frac{\alpha}{2}g_H > 0$ for any $\alpha > 0$
- Declining R&D productivity: Holds throughout range
- Higher $\alpha \rightarrow$ faster spreading, but lower spatial share of productivity decline

Counterfactual boundary: Patent counts grow over time, ruling out $\alpha \geq 2$

Backup: A Knowledge Production Function

◀ Return

Evidence of expansion:

- Patent filings: $\approx 500/\text{yr}$ (1840s) $\rightarrow$ 350,000/yr (2020s)
- Each discovery opens **adjacent research directions** Weitzman 1998; Scotchmer 1991
- Electricity $\rightarrow$ electronics $\rightarrow$ computing $\rightarrow$ AI...

Formalizing the intuition:

$$\dot{H} = \delta n \underbrace{(Q - \tau d/4)^\nu}_{\text{usable quality opens new directions}}$$

- $\nu = 1$ baseline; $0 \leq \nu \leq 1$ governs quality-to-frontier conversion
- Q : gain above inherited knowledge (the paper's $Q - Q_0$)

Key features:

- Uses *social* quality Q (incl. spillovers), not private effort q
- Net of adaptation costs—only “usable” quality opens new directions
- Standard supply-side KPF (Romer 1990; Jones 1995; Kortum 1997)

Backup: How Entry Costs Shape Equilibrium

[◀ Return](#)

As idea space H grows, what happens to d^*, n^*, q^*, p^* ?

Scenario	d^*, q^*, p^*	Varieties n^*
1. f constant	unchanged	$\uparrow$ (linear in H)
2. $f(H)$ decreasing	$\downarrow$ (clustering!)	$\uparrow\uparrow$ (faster)
3. $f(H)$ increasing (KPF baseline)	$\uparrow$ (spreading)	$\uparrow$ (grows with H)
4. $f(H)$ increasing rapidly	$\uparrow\uparrow$ rapidly	$\downarrow$ (fewer)

Only rising H, f is consistent with spreading out and expanding varieties

Backup: Forces Reducing Research Productivity

[◀ Return](#)

Forces reducing g_{TFP} :

$$g_{TFP} = \frac{dA}{dH} \cdot \dot{H} = \left(\underbrace{\frac{dq}{dH} \left[1 + \beta \left(1 - \frac{d}{\lambda} \right) \right]}_{\text{(1) Spillover attenuation: mult.}\downarrow} - \underbrace{\frac{\beta q}{\lambda} \frac{dd}{dH}}_{\text{(2) Spillover base: } q\uparrow} - \underbrace{\frac{\tau}{4} \frac{dd}{dH}}_{\text{Adapt. drag}} \right) \cdot \underbrace{\left[g_H^* + \frac{\delta \beta}{\gamma} \left(1 - \frac{d}{\lambda} \right) \right]}_{\text{(3) Frontier spillovers}\downarrow \text{ as } d\uparrow} \cdot H$$

Forces increasing Agg R&D:

$$\frac{d(\text{Agg R\&D})}{dH} = \underbrace{\frac{dn}{dH} \cdot [c(q) + f(H)]}_{\text{(6) Entry expansion}} + \underbrace{n \cdot c'(q)}_{\text{(4) Fishing out}} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{dq}{dH}}_{\text{(7) Quality scaling}} + \underbrace{n \cdot f'(H)}_{\text{(5) Burden of knowledge}}$$

Spatial Forces: 1, 2, 3, 6, 7 — **Familiar cost channels: 4, 5**

Backup: TFP and R&D Growth Equations

[◀ Growth rates](#)[◀ TFP regression](#)[◀ R&D regression](#)[◀ Decomposition](#)

TFP growth:

$$g_{TFP} = \underbrace{\dot{q} \left(1 + \beta - \frac{\beta d}{\lambda} \right)}_{\text{quality with spillovers}} - \underbrace{\left(\frac{\beta q}{\lambda} + \frac{\tau}{4} \right) \dot{d}}_{\text{spillover attenuation and adaptation}}$$

R&D growth:

$$g_{R\&D} = \underbrace{g_n}_{\text{Entry}} + \underbrace{\theta \cdot g_q}_{\text{Quality scaling}} + \underbrace{\theta \cdot g_q}_{\text{Fishing out}} + \underbrace{(1-\theta)g_f}_{\text{Burden of knowledge}}$$

where θ = variable cost share; $\alpha = 1$, $\eta = 1$

Backup: Growth Equations with General Cost Curvatures

[◀ Growth Rates](#)[◀ Decomposition](#)

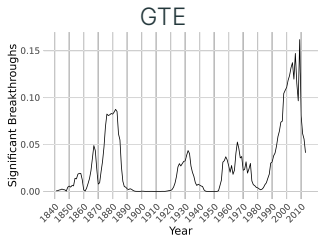
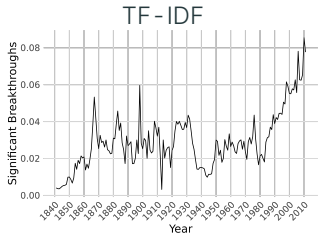
Component	General	Baseline ($\alpha = 1, \eta = 1$)
Entry cost	$f(H) = \phi H^\alpha$	ϕH
R&D cost	$c(q) = \frac{1}{2}\gamma q^{1+\eta}$	$\frac{1}{2}\gamma q^2$
Spacing growth	$g_d = \frac{\alpha}{2}g_H$	$\frac{1}{2}g_H$
Quality growth	$g_q = g_d$	$\frac{1}{2}g_H$
Entry growth	$g_n = (1 - \frac{\alpha}{2})g_H$	$\frac{1}{2}g_H$
Fixed cost growth	$g_f = \alpha g_H$	g_H

R&D growth equation:

$$g_{R\&D} = \underbrace{(1 - \frac{\alpha}{2})g_H}_{\text{Entry}} + \underbrace{\frac{\theta\alpha}{2}g_H}_{\text{Quality scaling}} + \underbrace{\frac{\theta\eta\alpha}{2}g_H}_{\text{Fishing out}} + \underbrace{(1 - \theta)\alpha g_H}_{\text{Burden of knowledge}}$$

Backup: Kelly et al. Breakthrough Replication

◀ Return



Kelly et al. (2021): Identify “breakthrough” patents using similarity to future patents

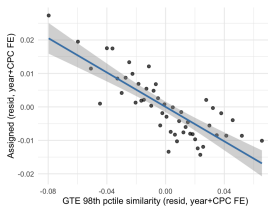
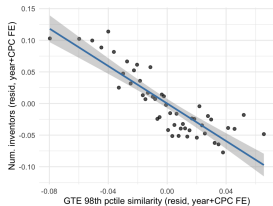
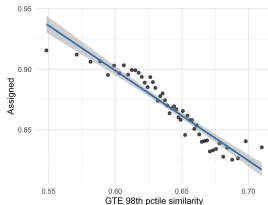
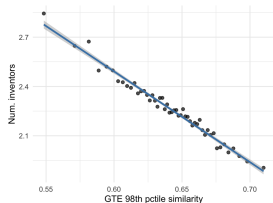
Our replication with GTE:

- Qualitative conclusions align (more breakthroughs today)
- Quantitative results more robust (less sensitivity to methodological choices)
- TF-IDF produces noisier breakthrough classification

Implication: Validated similarity measures improve downstream analyses

Backup: Spacing Predicts Investment and Quality

◀ Return



Model: $q^* = d/\gamma$ — more isolated inventors invest more in quality

4 q proxies: Co-inventors, assigned patents, 5-yr citations, KPSS patent value

Confirmed in cross-section and within technology classes over time

▶ Regression results

Spacing and Quality: Regression Results

[◀ Main deck](#)
[◀ Return](#)

	Co-Inventors	Firm Assignment	Citations (5-yr)	KPSS Value
Panel A: Cross-sectional, mean similarity				
GTE	-2.545*** (0.679)	-0.659*** (0.180)	6.347 (4.480)	-22.093** (9.036)
PaECTER	-4.928*** (1.002)	-1.723*** (0.424)	-36.681*** (8.383)	-122.904*** (46.101)
Panel B: Cross-sectional, 98th percentile similarity				
GTE	-1.477** (0.670)	-0.253* (0.131)	4.788 (3.220)	-32.531*** (7.022)
PaECTER	-1.067 (1.592)	-1.174*** (0.431)	-19.404*** (6.443)	-84.301* (43.556)
Observations	219,772	219,772	219,772	3,274,108
Fixed Effects	Year + CPC Class			
Panel C: Time-series, Δ mean similarity, CUSP (1836–2023)				
GTE	-0.011* (0.005)	—	—	—
PaECTER	-0.004** (0.001)	—	—	—
Observations	15,813			
Fixed Effects	Year + CPC Class			

Backup: From TFP Drag to the Accounting Contribution

◀ Return

The five-year regression implies a worsening spatial drag

$$\underbrace{-0.041}_{1948} \longrightarrow \underbrace{-0.136}_{2015} \text{ pp/year}$$

The change accounts for 6.8% of the TFP-growth slowdown

$$\frac{0.136 - 0.041}{1.4} = 6.8\%$$

Contribution to the decline in research productivity

$$6.8\% \times (-1.6\%/yr) = -0.11\%/yr$$

▶ TFP estimates

▶ Accounting

Backup: TFP Regression Results

◀ Return

	Annual		3 - Year	5 - Year
$b_1: -\Delta\text{Sim}$	-0.169*** (0.057)	-0.171** (0.083)	-0.278*** (0.095)	-0.269*** (0.098)
$b_2: \text{interaction}$	—	-0.015 (0.342)	-0.408 (0.320)	-0.571* (0.312)
$b_3: \text{Year}$	-2.67e-4*** (9.90e-5)	-2.62e-4** (9.99e-5)	-8.19e-4*** (1.91e-4)	-1.19e-3*** (2.70e-4)
<i>Annualized TFP drag, pp/year</i>				
1948	—	-0.082	-0.068	-0.041
1991	-0.084	-0.085	-0.139	-0.156
2015	—	-0.084	-0.127	-0.136

Standard errors in parentheses. Constant included. TFP: Bloom et al. (2020), 1948–2015.

Backup: Validation of Spillover Elasticity

[◀ Return](#)

Quasi-experimental estimates of R&D spillovers Bloom et al. 2013, Lucking et al. 2019

- Firm-level TFP elasticity to shocks to spillover pool
- SPILLTECH $\equiv$ sum of neighbors' R&D, weighted by idea distance
- IV: State R&D tax credit shocks

Ingredients:

- Bloom et al. 2013 (1981-2001): $\hat{\beta} = \mathbf{0.206}$
- Standard deviation $\log(\text{SPILLTECH}) = \mathbf{1.04}$
- Avg change in similarity (Bloom sample period): $\mathbf{-0.007\sigma/\text{yr}}$

Implied TFP drag from average rate of spreading out:

- $-0.007 \times 1.04 \times 0.206 = \mathbf{-0.15\%/yr}$ ✓

Backup: R&D Regression and Implied Parameters

[◀ R&D intuition](#)[◀ Calibration](#)

	Annual	3 - Year	5 - Year
α_2 : $-\Delta\text{Sim}$	0.165 (0.177)	0.448** (0.219)	0.438* (0.244)
α_1 : Year (1991 = 0)	$-2.88\text{e-}4$ ($3.05\text{e-}4$)	$-7.79\text{e-}4$ ($6.58\text{e-}4$)	$-1.65\text{e-}3^*$ ($9.65\text{e-}4$)
α_0 : Constant	0.034*** (0.006)	0.102*** (0.013)	0.173*** (0.018)
Implied variable-cost share θ	0.583	0.724	0.719
Implied frontier growth g_H^{1991}	2.40%/yr	2.66%/yr	2.70%/yr

Parameters use annualized intercepts and the approximate similarity-spacing mapping.

Standard errors in parentheses. R&D: Bloom et al. (2020), 1948–2015.

Backup: Calibration Details

[◀ Return](#)

Parameter	Baseline	Basis
Variable - cost share θ	0.69	NSF BERD labor share
Frontier growth g_H	2.67%/yr	$\frac{2}{3} \times 4.0\%/yr$
Entry - cost elasticity α	1	Linear entry costs
R&D cost curvature η	1	Quadratic variable costs

NSF labor costs approximate variable costs. Some labor costs are fixed; some non-labor costs are variable.

Backup: Separate Estimates Give Similar Magnitudes

[◀ Return](#)

	Regression	Benchmark
TFP drag, 1981–2001	–0.16 pp/yr	–0.15 pp/yr
Bloom et al. (2013) spillover elasticity		
Variable-cost share	0.719	0.69
NSF survey		
Frontier growth	2.70%/yr	2.67%/yr
Model identity		
	Data	Model
Spacing growth / R&D growth	0.2–0.4	1/3

[▶ Spillover calculation](#)[▶ TFP table](#)[▶ R&D table](#)

Backup: Detailed Spatial Decomposition

[◀ Return](#)

This is a **model-conditioned decomposition**, disciplined by external checks above.

Calibration: $\theta = 0.69$ (NSF) $g_H = 2.67\%/yr$ (Model identity $g_{R\&D} = \frac{3}{2}g_H$) $\alpha = 1, \eta = 1$ (baseline)

Backup: Detailed Spatial Decomposition

[◀ Return](#)

This is a **model-conditioned decomposition**, disciplined by external checks above.

Calibration: $\theta = 0.69$ (NSF) $g_H = 2.67\%/yr$ (Model identity $g_{R\&D} = \frac{3}{2}g_H$) $\alpha = 1, \eta = 1$ (baseline)

Component	Contribution
<i>TFP deceleration</i>	-1.6%/yr
Spatial drag worsened	-0.11%/yr
Unmodeled factors	-1.49%/yr
<i>R&D growth</i>	+4.0%/yr
Total R&D productivity decline, 1948–2015	-5.6%/yr

Spatial drag: Knowledge spillovers fade

[▶ Robustness](#)[▶ Growth equations](#)

Backup: Detailed Spatial Decomposition

[◀ Return](#)

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Unmodeled factors	-1.49%/yr
<i>R&D growth</i>	+4.0%/yr
Entry expansion $(1 - \frac{\alpha}{2})g_H$	+1.33%/yr
Quality scaling $(\theta \frac{\alpha}{2} g_H)$	+0.92%/yr
Fishing out $(\theta \eta \frac{\alpha}{2} g_H)$	+0.92%/yr
Burden of knowledge $(1 - \theta)(\alpha g_H)$	+0.83%/yr
Total R&D productivity decline, 1948–2015	-5.6%/yr

Entry expansion: More inventions on more territory

Quality scaling: Each inventor builds bigger, raising cost per unit TFP

[▶ Robustness](#)[▶ Growth equations](#)

Backup: Detailed Spatial Decomposition

[◀ Return](#)

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Burden of knowledge $(1 - \theta)(\alpha g_H)$	+0.83%/yr
Total R&D productivity decline, 1948–2015	−5.6%/yr
Spatial contribution (42%)	−2.36%/yr
Remaining contribution (58%)	−3.24%/yr

Sensitivity: 33–58% over the full parameter grid; 42–58% when $\alpha \leq 1$.

Spatial forces account for 42% of the long-run productivity decline

[▶ Robustness](#)[▶ Growth equations](#)

Backup: Entry Costs Govern the Spatial Share

[◀ Return](#)

Dominant uncertainty: α (entry cost curvature)

Entity growth suggests $\alpha \approx 0.67$ unique inventor growth
(2.0%/yr)

$\eta = 0.625$ from quasi-experiment Guceri-Liu 2019

Full parameter range: 33–58%

42–58% when $\alpha \leq 1$.

Entity growth proxies invention growth.

α	Spatial share (%)	
	$\eta = 1$	$\eta = 0.625$
0.50	55	58
0.75	48	51
1.00	42	46
1.25	37	41
1.50	33	37